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The great disappearing act: difficulties in doing “leadership”

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Abstract

We address ideas and talk about leadership in a research and development (R&D) company. The meaning that middle and senior managers ascribe to leadership is explored. We show how initial claims about leadership values and style tend to break down when managers are asked to expand on how they perceive their leadership and account for what they actually do in this respect. We raise strong doubts about leadership as a construct saying something valuable and valid about what managers do in this kind of setting. We also argue that thinking about leadership needs to take seriously the possibility of the nonexistence of leadership as a distinct phenomenon with great relevance for understanding organizations and relations in workplaces.

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1. Introduction

Leadership is a topic—or rather a label for a variety of more or less related issues—that has received attention in thousands of empirical studies, theoretical work, and popular writings offering more or less well-grounded recipes for successful managerial work. Still, there is considerable discontent with what has been accomplished and it can be argued that we still do not understand leadership particularly well (Andriessen & Drenth, 1984; Barker, 1997; Sashkin & Garland, 1979; Wright, 1996; Yukl & Nemeroff, 1979). There are good reasons to be much more open than has been common about the paradigmatic assumptions, methodo-

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logical preferences, and ideological commitments permeating the majority of leadership studies and writings. Such openness may involve an interest in understanding local context and the cultural dimensions of leadership and the centrality of language and narrative (discourse) in trying to reveal (or construct) leadership and a skeptical attitude to the “realness” or at least “robustness” of leadership (Alvesson & Deetz, 2000).

Claims to openness easily means a selective questioning attitude—one is open in certain respects and closed in others. We try to be aware of the elements of closure involved in all writings, in particular academic journal writing. Nevertheless, we hope to reveal common thinking in leadership studies, as reflected in U.S.-dominated, objectivist-oriented (cf. S. D. Hunt, 1991)¹ research and popular writings.

We investigate “leadership” (where we initially use quotation marks to convey our underlying message) in a science-based research and development (R&D) company. Here, there is a setting characterized by a high degree of complexity and ambiguity and a highly educated workforce. This is a context that clearly affects relationships between managers and their subordinates. Arguably, it is important to consider the specific organizational and professional setting in order to understand how people relate to, talk about, and possibly practice—or fail to practice—leadership. We explore in some depth how people in this organization construct their leadership and also how they are only partially successful in constructing an integrated, coherent view of how they see and practice leadership. Apart from investigating talk, ideas, and to a more moderate extent, the practice of leadership, we also address the more general theoretical question on how we can understand leadership. A part of that understanding is to think seriously about the ontological aspects of the phenomenon.

Most people seem to have little doubt that leadership is a “real” phenomenon and indeed an important one in the large majority of organizations. Most leadership researchers tend to agree that it exists, although there are a few that at least acknowledge problems with confusing the label leadership with an assumed empirical reality. As noted by Luthans (1979), “Too often theorists forget that leadership or ‘influence’ are merely labels that are attached to hypothetical constructs. Too often, the hypothetical construct is treated as the empirical reality” (p. 202). However, the quotation marks initially used by Luthans in referring to leadership do not lead to radical questioning of traditional methodological or theoretical assumptions. After the initial, seemingly skeptical stance toward leadership, Luthans joins the typical treatment of “leadership (as) a reciprocal, interactive process . . .” (p. 208) and the quotation marks are abandoned. Hence, leadership “is” even though there are divergent opinions about its substantial significance. Some downplay the impact of leadership (e.g., Andersen, 2000; Meindl, Ehrlich, & Dukerich, 1985; Pfeffer, 1978), whereas most emphasize its significance for organizational processes and outcomes (e.g., Fiedler, 1996; House & Aditya, 1997). (Substance and outcomes here refer to effects on behaviors, production, and financial results, i.e., not only beliefs and attitudes.)

¹ Frequently such research is referred to as “positivist.” However, S. D. Hunt (1991) has argued that such usage is historically inaccurate, given a detailed reading of the positivist movement literature. Hence, we use the term “objectivist” here and later.

Another approach to this subject matter is to assume less in terms of the realness and robustness of leadership. Embracing a more open approach than “forcing” respondents to respond to questionnaire statements about leadership thus producing this phenomenon could be to look more carefully into less constrained treatment of the theme of leadership and then interpret what this seems to suggest about considering various possibilities. One possibility is that there is a real phenomenon behind the discussion about leadership, another is that there is not, at least not in any direct and nonambiguous sense.

Here, we postpone and, to some extent, sidestep taking a firm theoretical and methodological stance on the ontological nature of the material we are dealing with and its possible referents. Instead we keep various options in mind, and arrive at several partly different possible conclusions guided by realistic, cognitive meaning and discursive lines of reasoning. All point in the same direction as they question mainstream thinking about leadership—and a great deal of other organization and social science thinking, for that matter.

Here, we may be read as embracing an incoherent or even self-defeating position of investigating something that we are not convinced exists in any robust or substantive sense. But we are not too worried about this. In a minimalistic sense leadership exists—there is discussion about it and presumably also ideas, values, or aspirations that inspire this discussion, or are produced by it (some would say discursively constituted). There are certainly discourses and attributions of leadership in organizations. To what extent leadership exists also in other senses, for example, as a distinct set of behaviors or as a distinct idea and set of meanings guiding managerial work, is a more open question. Empirical material can shed some light on this issue.

The article has three objectives, of which the two initial ones are most important and equal in weight. The first, and basically empirical, is to explore leadership in a corporate context characterized by long-term projects, a high level of complexity, and knowledge intensity. Managing scientists may mean a leadership situation different from managing in a mass production context, although some of our senior interviewees said that the former does not differ from managing more conventional industries. The second is to investigate to what extent it makes sense to claim that leadership exists as a reasonable coherent phenomenon, whether this is viewed as a behavioral style, a set of orientations or a role position in relationship with others, or if leadership should be interpreted in other ways.

The first objective and the specific empirical case examined here means that we do not address the second objective in abstract and general terms, but primarily based on the case and aim to illuminate some aspects of the leadership situation for managers in this kind of knowledge-intensive, complex organizational context. The third objective concerns the methodology of studying phenomena such as leadership—and here we address how to approach the relationship between talk, meaning and practice. This third objective is less ambitious and salient here, but we argue that our text is relevant.

The article is divided into the following parts. First there is a very brief skeptical review of mainstream leadership thinking, then we outline two alternative foci, concentrating on levels of meaning and discourse. The next section presents our study method and the case organization. Then there is a long section where six examples of leadership are interpreted. After that the reader will find our conclusions.

2. What is leadership? Or rather is there really leadership?

The literature addressing leadership—even though in this the earlier mentioned quotation marks are never used as there is great confidence that leadership is there and can be studied—is huge. There are numerous theories and an enormous amount of empirical work. Most of this work is American and objectivist oriented. Qualitative work is rare but has been increasingly common. Sometimes the field is divided into three broad categories: leader traits, leader behavioral style, and symbolic leadership (Andersen, 2000). There is a trend from an emphasis on the former to symbolic leadership. A crucial idea in this is that “leadership is realized in the process whereby one or more individuals succeed in attempting to frame and define the reality of others” (Smircich & Morgan, 1982, p. 258). Also here, work on charisma, value-based leadership, transformational leadership, and the like is included. The focus is on the leaders and how they affect the meanings, ideas, values, commitments, and emotions of the subordinates. We will not review this literature further as our approach is different and we will not connect to these theories in any detail. (For reviews, see, e.g., Bryman, 1996; House & Aditya, 1997; Palmer & Hardy, 2000; Yukl, 1989). There is a general discontent with the results in the field (Andriessen & Drenth, 1984; Barker, 1997; Smith & Peterson, 1988; Yukl & Nemeroff, 1979). Sashkin and Garland (1979) conclude that “By any objective measure, the study of leadership has failed to produce generally accepted, practically useful, and widely applied scientific knowledge” (p. 65). According to Yukl (1989) the field

... is presently in a state of ferment and confusion. Most of the theories are beset with conceptual weaknesses and lack strong empirical support. Several thousand empirical studies have been conducted on leadership effectiveness, but most of the results are contradictory and inconclusive. (p. 253)

Fiedler (1996) complains that “there has been much moaning and groaning in the past that we didn’t know anything worthwhile about leadership, that leadership theories and research lacked focus and were chaotic, and some writers asked even whether there is such a thing as leadership” (p. 241). The commitment to an objectivist paradigm promising the accumulation of knowledge through development and verification of hypothesis has not led to the delivery of the goods (Alvesson & Deetz, 2000). Practitioners seem to view academic leadership as abstract, remote, and of limited relevance (Burack, 1979; House & Aditya, 1997).

There is a wide spectrum of definitions of leadership and focus on the subject matter. Yukl (1989) notes that “the numerous definitions of leadership that have been proposed appear to have little else in common” than involving an influence process. He seems to attribute part of the lack of progress in the field to its variety and, like many others in the field, wants more homogeneity and coherence. However, we doubt that a common definition of leadership is practically possible, would not be very helpful if it were, does not hit the target, and may also obstruct new ideas and interesting ways of thinking. That two thirds of all leadership texts do not define the subject matter may be read as supporting the view that leadership is indeed difficult to pin down (Rost, cited in Palmer & Hardy, 2000).

A valuable definition of leadership must refer to a phenomenon that can be delimited—it makes little sense to equate leadership with any influence process. The degree of diversity that leadership is supposed to refer to must be restricted. But this is hardly the case, given that most academic leadership talk seems to refer to a broad spectrum of different phenomena. Leadership is typically defined in general terms. The ambition is to say something of relevance across quite diverse settings. Informal leadership may well refer to (formal) subordinates guiding (formal) superiors, not just managers interacting with their (formal) subordinates. It is often used to illuminate the behaviors, styles, personalities, and the like, of quite diverse groups. This diversity means that a coherent definition with universal aspirations may tell us relatively little in terms of the richness and complexity of the phenomena to which it supposedly refers (Alvesson & Deetz, 2000).

Yukl (1989) writes that “leadership is defined broadly in this article to include influencing task objectives and strategies, influencing commitment and compliance in task behavior to achieve these objectives, influencing group maintenance and identification, and influencing the culture of an organization” (p. 253). This definition is similar to most other definitions. Knights and Willmott (1992), for example, cite it and adapt it in their article. But one could hardly let the words leadership and culture change place and then have a definition of culture. Or swap leadership and strategy. One could also replace leadership with organizational structure, job design, social identity, or something else. [Weick (1985) has used this trick to show how some definitions of strategy and culture are roughly the same.]

Thus, it is rather difficult to claim that leadership as a general term and object of study stands in a clear relationship to a particular, distinct group of phenomena possible to conceptualize in a uniform manner, for example, through the signifier leadership. The variation of definitions of leadership also indicates the noncorrespondence between leadership and something specific out there in organizations and other social settings. The two problems indicated are interrelated: The social worlds of interest for leadership researchers do not easily lend themselves to neat categorization and ordering, and language use has its limitations in relation to the goal of fixing meaning through definitions.

The first of the problems above is partly addressed by Meindl et al. (1985) who argue that researchers and practitioners have developed a heroic conception of leadership: “... leadership has assumed a romanticized, larger-than-life role.” (p. 79). According to Meindl et al. this view emanates from the tendency among organizational observers to ascribe leadership to complex and ambiguous organizational events, although it is highly uncertain whether leadership had anything to do with those events or not. In the absence of unambiguous information leadership is thus often called for as an interpretative device. Although this research displays uncertainty concerning the significance of leadership and cautions us about the impact of leaders it nevertheless subscribes to the view that leadership does exist, especially considering its “symbolic role” (Pfeffer, 1981). But does leadership exist, that is, beyond attributions or discourse (language use)?

That there is frequent use of the signifier and that common sense and conventional wisdom inform us that leadership is and that it is not only important but necessary for organizations do not lead to a decisive answer. Research cannot answer that question without relying heavily on assumptions about leadership. As is broadly recognized, empirical material is produced/

constructed through paradigm-dependent operations. All data on leadership—as on all phenomena—are theory impregnated. Most research on leadership is based on a set of assumptions and a methodology that means that leadership is effectively produced: Respondents are interpolated as leaders and asked to report about their leadership, through completing questionnaires or answering questions. Seldom are they asked to consider whether leadership is a relevant term or to think critically about it. Research on the whole produces versions of leadership without seriously considering whether influencing task objectives, strategies, commitment, and compliance refers to something with the slightest degree of uniformity and identity and whether a general theory about a possible wide set of highly diverse phenomena is possible.

To avoid variation, particular procedures aiming to standardize responses are used. Subjects in experiments and respondents to questionnaires are forced to subordinate themselves to expressions of the researcher's assumptions and design (Deetz, 1996), for example, the researcher's opinion of what is relevant or the way that the researcher has chosen to structure the position and provide response alternatives for the subjects. Through such procedures leadership can be produced as an empirical phenomenon. The hiding of researchers producing leadership through forcing the research objects to respond to prestructured, standardized, easily processed response alternatives is a major problem with the ideal of objectivity in social science. Major problems here are that too much is assumed and there is a neglect of ambiguity.

To achieve something that appears to be objective, variation must be reduced and standardization and simplification sought out. The rich variety and diversity of the social world is suppressed for the sake of fitting procedures that give the impression of objectivity and make generalizable theory and results possible. Quantification has this quality, that is, the rhetorical appeal of numbers obscures the processes of construction and interpretation of the members are built upon. The standardization of social phenomena risks involving a basic distortion of social reality, not in the sense of portraying reality falsely in opposition to accurately, but in terms of imputing certainty and order at the expense of openness and indeterminacy. Leadership as a potentially problematic construct is then left unexamined although some suggest that it is overestimated and romanticized in terms of substantial influence and control of organizations (Meindl et al., 1985; Pfeffer, 1978).

The line taken here is the opposite. The empirical material will be given a fair chance to kick back at the very idea of leadership.

We then follow a trend from abstract, general categories and efforts to standardize meaning toward an increased focus on local patterns, where the cultural and institutional context, the language use, and the meaning creation patterns driven by participants are in focus. The researcher then takes seriously the ambiguity of that which may be interpreted as leadership. As leadership covers a wide diversity of actions, feelings, thoughts, relations, and social processes, the merits of applying this concept—interpretive device—are seldom self-evident. To understand what leadership is about means care about the vocabulary applied and respect for the contextual character of language and meaning. Such respect calls for intimacy in relation to the phenomenon under study and depth of understanding at the expense of abstraction, generalizability, and the artificial separation of theory and data.

We are not, however, totally liberal in our approach to leadership. The study focuses on managers, broadly expected to exercise leadership, so the interest is in managerial leadership. Within broad parameters, leadership for us has something to do with asymmetrical relationships, influencing processes, and where people in some kind of formal dependency relationship are targeted. Much managerial work—cash-flow management, listening to superiors, passing on plans from seniors, and determining that people complete reports, for example—does not seem for us to be of immediate interest in this specific study.

3. Alternative perspectives, concentrating on the levels of meaning and discourse

What is defined as leadership calls for not just a theoretical definition but also close consideration of what a particular group means by leadership. For different groups the term has different meaning and value. In the military and in professional groups, leadership has very different connotations.

One approach is to listen to various groups and organizations and find out when and why the “natives” talk about leadership, what they mean by it, their beliefs, values, and feelings around leadership, and different versions and expressions of it. Leaders and leadership can then be seen as organizational symbols, the orientations toward them are then not treated as facts about leadership, as such, but more as clues to understand organizational cultures (Alvesson, 2002). Does leadership (or managerial work), in specific organizations, refer to the strong and decisive decision maker, the superior technician or professional, the team builder and coach, the educator and developer of people or the results-oriented number cruncher carefully monitoring and putting pressure on people to perform? How people talk and in other ways express sentiments about leaders and leadership (managers and managerial work) then indicates wider cultural patterns on human nature, social relations, hierarchies, power, and so forth. This approach would partly avoid the difficulties in defining leadership as once and for all valid over time and space.

However, it is important here to keep two options in mind. One is to investigate the level of meaning, that is, the ideas, understandings, and orientations of people. This is sometimes referred to as “the native’s point of view.” Another is the level of discourse, here understood as language use in a social context (Potter & Wetherell, 1987). (The term discourse is difficult and people use it very loosely. For a review of the more common ways of talking about discourse, see Alvesson & Kärreman, 2000). Discourse then focuses on the level of explicit language use, and does not try to move beyond surface meaning. Thus we can approach accounts in two ways: as revealing stable, underlying meaning or as constituting a temporal meaning, produced within discourse. Although frequently seen as competing positions to which a researcher must choose sides, one may also keep both in mind as part of one’s interpretive repertoire, of course without conflating the two and keeping in mind alternative interpretations (Alvesson & Sköldberg, 2000).

In relationship to leadership then we can investigate and address empirical material in terms of the ideas, understandings, beliefs and orientations, and/or how it appears as a theme in specific accounts, as something that is constructed in particular ways in conversations of

various kinds. One can conflate the levels of meanings and text—as is often done (in particular by those privileging discourse)—but there are interesting options following from *not* doing so. One can remain open about treating leadership talk in interviews as indications concerning meanings versus expression of discourse and compare the insights following from the two different lines of interpretations.

4. Six minicases on leadership: methodology

The context of this work is a fairly ambitious case study of an international biotech company working in a field characterized by long-term product development and great difficulties in measuring results and making judgements on vital issues. The organization can thus be seen as a highly complex and ambiguous one. Product development is characterized by a high level of serendipity.

The entire study includes about 40 interviews, mainly with managers on different levels and some scientists, plus observations of management team meetings. The entire project also concerns a number of issues, including leadership. Here, we report a part of the project focusing on how managers describe their own leadership.

The empirical material was produced in interviews, rather loosely structured conversations, in which people were asked to talk about topics of interest for them in their roles as managers in a knowledge-intensive context. Initially we asked them to talk about their experiences as managers and if there were any particularly challenging issues that they felt as especially important for their present work tasks and in their relations with subordinates and superiors.

Some embarked on leadership as one such particularly challenging topic seemingly very important for them to elaborate upon. Others were asked more explicitly to talk about their leadership in terms of how they look upon it and possibly practice it. Managers thus talked rather freely and unreservedly about leadership, what it means for them, and to what extent they are able to practice it. No particular hints or specifications of how leadership should be described were given. In the interviews managers usually initially framed leadership in terms of the more fashionable versions. When further outlining the topic they usually seemed to diverge from what was initially stated. In analysis we have then identified their principal statement about leadership, for example, a basic claim about the vital aspect of their leadership. We have then followed the reasoning of the interviewees, either as they continue talking themselves or as a response to a question in which they are asked to clarify or exemplify how they “do” the leadership they express.

Below we present six minicases of leadership. These six are fairly typical for the empirical material we have and chosen partly because of that and partly to show some variation and thus present a richer picture. The number six is dictated by a compromise between two considerations: to have several cases and to present and interpret these with some depth. The point with qualitative studies is not statistical representation but the insightful examples. However, we want to give some credibility to the claim that we make that the findings are not based on highly unusual individual cases, but of potential broader interest. To give the reader

a fair chance to assess the material and follow our interpretations we give some space to the interviewee accounts and our interpretations of these.

We thus represent the material in some detail, having done fairly modest editing and selection. Our approach is in-between the strict focus on the details of language use favored by discourse and conversation analysts (Potter & Wetherell, 1987; Silverman, 1993) and conventional qualitative researchers typically presenting carefully selected, edited, and persuasive accounts supporting a point that the researcher is making. Our excerpts are fairly long and somewhat messy—we do not want to edit the interview material very much. Of course they are selected based on the objective of making a point and guided by our interpretations of the central passages in the interviews about the interviewees' view of their leadership, but the material presented here should not prevent readers from making alternative interpretations of it.

5. Minicases of leadership

5.1. Case 1: Making sure that the creativity is there—or not knowing how

In the first case we show talk of leadership by a higher level senior manager. The manager is confronted by the question of what leadership comes down to when in charge of presumably rather independent and self-governing scientists. He explains that:

I mean, I love being at R&D. And there is some problem with the people you mention. Scientists don't like to get managed. But actually, if there isn't any leadership, scientists complain. A lot of scientists would not class me as a scientist by now, but I'm trained as a scientist, I didn't like to be told what to do. But on the other hand, I loved someone who tried to persuade me to go in a particular direction. I think it's about *how* you do it. I do believe we need managers, but I don't think, we can't manage some of the old style traditional top down management. I think it has to be about leading and developing people. In terms of discovering drugs it's gotta be through . . . science, but also it's got to be on . . . projects. In . . . the . . . former Biotech and UBB there was very good science going on in areas where it was unlikely that they would discover drugs. The scientists involved . . . were largely proud of the quality in that. But . . . if you accept that Biotech and UBB is here to discover drugs, then it's wasted effort. We should put the creativity and the talent onto the most likely projects. And I think managers by leading projects and developing the scientists try to put the best scientists to the best projects. But it's not that they can't do it themselves, . . . it's the quality of the science and the commitment of the scientists . . . it's scientists who put in the extra energy, who think of the compounds they're gonna make in the bath at home or when watching the kids play soccer . . . that's what discovers drugs . . . and managers are there to try to harness that and make sure that the creativity is there. (Manager M)

Well, . . . a strength and a weakness of mine is that I tend to be cheerful so I go into the field rather than . . . uh yes, as a scientist I work through logic, but sometimes it's a judgement call. And I think a lot of it is judgement, there isn't a written policy that says

this is how you discover drugs or this is how to do the right thing. There's a huge . . . uh, sounds very imprecise and maybe it is, but . . . uh, it's rather like a successful sports team, where you got lots of creative talent. And you also got less creative, less talented people who do a lot of hard work that is essential. Just as a football manager couldn't tell how its done, but the best football managers can succeed in . . . with the best . . . well not the best, sorry, and can really succeed if they get the best players. I think it's rather similar at discovery. There is a lot of people management. Trying to coach people, trying to persuade people to harness energy . . .

The interviewee emphasizes different key themes going in different directions: One important theme is indicated by the interviewee thinking "it has to be about leading and developing people," which indicates providing active direction and encourage personal development, presumably in the long run. He then emphasizes personnel planning: "it is put the creativity and the talent onto the most likely projects," which has little to do with leading and developing. (Staffing projects based on a utilization of existing talent and developing new talent rest on different logics, even though they may converge in specific instances.) Managers should also encourage people to put in extra energy.

The interviewer, in a moment of reflexivity, puts it well when he says that it "sounds very imprecise and maybe it is . . ." The validity and relevance of the sports metaphors can be questioned—at a minimum they are insensitive to the specifics of the actual field, which among other things lacks short-term goals and where the elements of competition and results are extremely weak in a daily work context. Efforts to persuade "going in a particular direction," "to harness energy," to coach people and "people management" are, to say the least, vague. To "try to put the best scientists to the best projects" appears reasonable but trivial and group composition may be a vital task for managers, but the meaning of "best" is obscure—at first it is "the best scientists" that is emphasized, then it is (individual) "scientists who put in the extra energy" that is crucial, and then later it is not so much the individual scientists as the team that is central.

The idea of what the leader is supposed to do then shifts frequently, even though the interviewee claims that what the minisection, sentence, or even part of a sentence is about is "the thing" about leadership. Leading and developing gives way to staffing, which gives way to making sure people are creative, which then is followed by emphasis on the right motivation and energy, and so forth. The best individuals and the team (including "less talented people who do a lot of hard work") also replace each other as significant. Creativity comes back frequently in the account.

All the viewpoints are reasonable and certainly many things matter, but the account gives a rather vague and incoherent view on leadership. The role of managers to "make sure that the creativity is there" seems difficult to occupy. Presumably managers are not there reminding scientists about drugs when they are in the bath at home or watching the kids play soccer. What the interviewee actually does, apart from being cheerful and trying to put the best people and some less talented but hardworking people on the best projects, remains unclear. If leadership is supposed to refer to something that has coherence and specificity, not much leadership comes through in the account.

5.2. Case 2: *A common vision—to produce infrastructure*

In the second case we meet a middle manager in charge of a support unit. Firstly she answers to an open ended and rather general question of what leadership means for her. She explains that:

I think the biggest challenge I have is that I have to take a lot of small groups and individuals who are very independent, all looking at slightly different things, and try to make them work as a team, . . . an idea to fit with the supersite . . . and across the nation's border. (Manager H)

When asked to explain how she accomplishes that she responds:

Well, how do I work? Well, I think it's important that we have a common understanding . . . a common vision really and a common purpose, and a common purpose is, I believe, what I just described to you, that we could provide infrastructure, we do whatever is necessary to allow the scientists to produce these great projects . . . which is our future, so I think it's absolutely essential that we work as a team, I mean, as much flexibility as possible, it's a small team and I need to work on how we can provide cover for each other. Even if only one person normally doing a job who is on holiday.

When asked to be more explicit about how she works to provide leadership she says that:

. . . you have to be 'on message' all the time, having to decide what you vision, what are your values that you're working to, what's the direction that the group is going in; you personally as a manager have to live that vision.

She further says that to live a vision means that:

It's well, things like, for example, take every opportunity to say 'You can do that,' say to people that 'you're just the person I'd like to talk to' so it's promoting a team and promoting can and should be doing, saying to people 'have you thought about putting some work into this team' or conversely 'we ought to be doing that . . .' so that you are constantly thinking of what should we be doing and what could we be doing, what are we best at, what could we do and try not to get diverted because quite often it could be that someone ends up doing something just because it helps but he may not be the best person . . . (Manager H)

The biggest challenge for the interviewed manager is, according to her account, to make people work as a team, which basically means providing cover for people that are away from work. Vital here is a "vision" and, she says, "and a common purpose is, I believe, . . . that we could provide infrastructure, we do whatever is necessary to allow the scientists to produce these great projects . . . which is our future." As a vision, "to provide infrastructure" is vague.

Adding that scientists “produce great projects” and “our future” may be more in line with what is expected of people producing visions, but is somewhat remote for the team members as they are not expected to try to evaluate and give priority to “great projects” compared to those of less significance for the future.

“To live the vision” seems to mean to be positive, encouraging, and supportive to the coworkers and, with connection to the team building objective, suggesting to people to put “some work into this team.” Vision (common purpose) then tends to be reduced to making individuals feel positive and creating a good spirit in the group—something that does not really concern a common purpose.

5.3. Case 3: The team is important—leadership means abdicating from deciding

In this particular case we turn to a senior manager who is asked to specify his leadership. He contends that:

... my view is that it is teamwork and everyone is important, everyone is needed. OK, key scientists are important ... we must be prepared to reward them in a whole new way as compared to what we've done. To me it is extremely important to emphasize the team, the whole team. If you have an idea and you are unable to execute it, it is worthless. I've got plenty of ideas and I'm going around and spreading these among people. But one thing which I think is important from a leadership point of view is that those responsible for the projects also decide upon which ideas they want to pursue. It's not me who should tell them that. I tell them what ideas I have and often they say: 'that's no good, so we don't like it'. And that's perfectly OK for me. Sometimes they think it's good and then they appropriate it. But the important issue is that they as a group decide by themselves to carry on. (Manager A)

This statement on leadership indicates that the manager—in this case superior to the project manager—participates in discussions and offers ideas, but without any persistence or eagerness to make the key scientists respond. There is no asymmetry or privileged direction provision involved: The manager places himself on the same footing as the others. There is also a rather strong abdication from deciding: In terms of leadership what is important is that those responsible for projects must decide. The meaning of leadership then seems to be abstaining from taking a leader position.

It is also worth noting that the interviewee goes back and forth in emphasizing the key unit in this business. The first sentence states plainly that this is teamwork: All are important. Then he says that “key scientists” are important, which must, per definition, be true. He then underscores this statement by claiming that we must reward them in a completely different way than previously. This seems to be a strong statement in favor of the value of key scientists to the company. But then, the entire team reenters the picture, with formidable strength: “For me it is enormously important to emphasize the team, the entire team.” The team then seems to best the key scientists in the ranking of the interviewee. The account is incoherent: The key scientists, in particular, should be rewarded (presumably far more than

the rest) and the entire team should be emphasized. This indicates a confused view on how leadership is to be exercised.

5.4. Case 4: To get people to think—without thinking how this can be done

In this case, a senior manager describes himself as reactive. When people confront him with a problem his response is to “get them to think.” He explains that:

Perhaps this is a different management style, if people come to me with a problem I give them my advise with, ‘I’ve seen this before and we did it this way.’ Perhaps more normal modern management would be to ask them ‘you know we have this problem, let’s work on it together’ until they actually think about it and not just rely on me and ‘ten years ago we did it this way,’ they actually think about it, the thought process is there so next time there’s problem, not the same, its never quite the same, they have the thought process and they can . . . , and if they need reassurance you can say ‘well there’s two ways of doing this, I favor this way and you do that and what do you think.’ So there I can see that should really get them to start thinking and not just giving them your own advise, get them to think. (Manager J)

When required to explain how he is able to get his subordinates to think, he says that:

It’s not easy but trying to break the problems to its fundamentals, what is the real problem rather than just perception . . . and then . . . let’s look at it . . . this takes time . . . and its very easy to say ‘just do it this way’ you know, but the better method is to break a problem down to its fundamentals and just get them to start thinking things through, whether you need a piece of paper and a whiteboard or whatever, and that’s how you should do it (laugh) and I try and do it sometimes and sometimes it just goes . . .

When further asked about how often he sees his subordinates and breaks down problems to their fundamentals he says:

Not often at Kleindorff, because . . . if you like, well, the fact that Christiane Surm has taken over yesterday says a lot about her, her staff will go to her and they will go to me when she’s on holiday and when she’s over here and I’ll help them. You talked about the fundamentals but quite often, because they worked with her, they come over and they got this problem and I’ve looked and said that ‘I think there are two way of answering it and I favor this way’ so they’ve already been through that process because they’ve worked with her for two or three years and that’s how she’s trained to think, so there wasn’t so much of that from Kleindorff, because of her and her four-director court. There’s a little bit more from here, . . . it didn’t happen that often, perhaps not often enough . . .

When asked to specify interactions with subordinates about a problem the manager said, that “I think there are two way of answering it and I favor this way.” This response is

inconsistent with his claim earlier in the interview to have a management style that “should really get them to start thinking and not just giving them your own advise, get them to think.” In addition to the confusion on this point, it is worth noting that he says that his strongest statement about what leadership means for him was seldom exercised, at least “not often” is mentioned several times.

5.5. Case 5: Leadership as management of meaning and shaping of context—or the context shaping the unmanagement of meaning

In the fifth case, we indicate response of a higher level senior manager who suggests that a central aspect of leadership is walking around meeting scientists, which he describes as the seemingly insignificant moments when strategies are practiced. He explains that:

One must ask a scientist: ‘Are there any new exciting results’ and ‘how did those experiments turn out’? If you just ask those questions and then proceed, you exhibit an interest for the research, but if you stay a minute longer and ask ‘far, far away what do you think the candidate drug is’ or ‘what is the really big problem that you have to master,’ it’s just two examples, but to be able to convert in practice, in the little moments, when you formulate strategy or have a leadership meeting, to always have this balance . . . (Manager S)

The manager understands that this style demands a strong presence from him among his subordinates. However, he says that:

I wish that I would have been able to be out among them more, but it’s . . . I do believe that you should be present and visible and exploit informal meeting points, create contacts . . .

The interviewee says that leadership is about emphasizing the broader picture and encouraging people to have the overall purpose in mind. Leadership is said to be about balancing operative matters with encouragement of broader orientations (“visions”).

The examples given are specific and may be seen as good illustrations of management of meaning in which the work is framed according to the appropriate larger context and an important long-term consideration receives attention.

However, just staying an additional minute—as the interviewee says—may be of limited importance and may trivialize the matter. In an ideal world, one minute may make a difference, but in complex settings, such as the present one, it is highly uncertain whether any meaningful response to a question such as “what is the really big problem” can be produced in a few minutes. More significant is that the follow-up question indicates that the manager seldom has the time to do what he himself describes as something that “you have to do.” Other tasks, constraints, and priorities thus take precedence and there is little opportunity for this kind of leadership act. The balance between operational matters and the framing of the work that a person’s mind better incorporates the overall purpose seems to be tipping strongly toward operational activities and prerequisites. It is uncertain how much

management of meaning is produced. The context rather forms the “unmanagement” of meaning.

5.6. Case 6: Leadership as value talk—key value is to listen

In the final case, we turn to a senior manager who elaborates upon leadership as dialogue, closeness, and presence. For him, leadership is:

That we discuss very much together—what is our basic attitude. What are the grounds for how we are going to work between and within the teams, so that we don’t have different demands and different We can have different leader styles, we are allowed to have that. We are not allowed to display ... what separates us, because it is so much about governing the group so that we together see, ‘What do we stand for?’ It’s here one sees values and trying to elevate those values that one also sees the people and not only the results. This means that I try to meet the project leaders ... to be available. So my role is to be a coach, not the one who says to every person what they should do on every occasion. But also to be present in order to discuss ideas. Moreover, also to ... coordinate the operations to remove bureaucracies ... and to document resources (Manager F)

When asked to further explain how one works with basic stances and values the manager maintains that:

They [the colleagues] can put forward a suggestion, but the suggestion is discussed so that everyone who is a member of the group has a right to comment upon it and so that everyone listens to those persons. Also, that everyone feels that: ‘we’re in,’ and that you take a common responsibility for the work that is produced. And I mean that one has to listen to each and everyone, otherwise you’re not at team Secondly, it is extremely important that ideas exist, there are experiences outside the group. It could be a very experienced person from the GA department who has things that are needed for the project It is also an opportunity for learning for a ... new person to learn about experiences that exist. And as ... project leader you have to see that everyone feels equally valuable in the group ... I try to make myself available when I’m needed.

The basic attitude, “what we stand for, values ...” is viewed as central in leadership. Core values seem to focus on being available for discussions, listening and being receptive to people’s points of view. Nothing is said about what all this listening and communication should lead to—the importance of the basic attitude outside meeting situations is unclear. There is an element of downplaying the significance of results: “Try to bring forward values that you should consider people and not just results.” The manager also talks about conveying experiences among subordinates, which differs from the idea of what he formulated as the critical issue, shaping basic attitudes, because the basic attitudes presumably concern more than just listening.

6. Summing up the six cases

In virtually all these examples the interviewed managers put forward a notion, that is, several versions of leadership in accordance with contemporary fashionable scripts concerning how one should conduct leadership. In this respect all managers appear fairly informed and progressive. However, when explaining the topics, the view of their leadership becomes vague or even self-contradictory, the initial positioning almost melts away. At the end of the interview accounts, there is not much leadership left intact.

The disappearance acts are carried out in different ways:

In Case 1, the manager reveals the business success formula that the leader is supposed to realize, but creates a smokescreen around it, pointing in different directions and ends with the somewhat mysterious objective of to “harness energy.” Here, if one is impressed by the example given, harnessing energy presumably means turning subordinates into fanatics, thinking about the task when interacting with one’s children, and so forth.

In Case 2, the solution to what the manager claims to be “the biggest challenge” is a vision that only states the function of the unit: working with infrastructure. The vision is to be what we are. Any notion of the manager’s leading through vision or with vision then falls flat.

In Case 3, the manager is eager to let the subordinates decide, but here there is an expectation that the subordinates also listen to the ideas that the manager wants to present to them. Leadership is then to offer ideas and refrain from actively trying to get people to accept them. Leadership here amounts to avoiding the determination pursuit of a specific direction.

In Case 4, the interviewee indicates his overall approach to management, to “make people think” and presumably (to put it more in management jargon) encourage independence, initiative, and the development of people. The follow-up on that indicates an inability to substantiate it. The specific example provided then contradicts the claim “this is what I favor.”

In Case 5, the manager tries to squeeze in a one-minute version of management of meaning. However, asking brief questions about complex problems and linking specific problems people are struggling with to big successes over which they have only partial responsibility appears tricky. The major problem here is time. Other priorities take an upper hand and the time to carry out the leadership claimed to be so important is highly limited.

In Case 6, the idea of leadership is to listen and, as an act where activity and influence reaches its peak, also encourage others to listen to their peers. There is little sense of direction involved here as listening can lead anywhere, or nowhere.

7. The disappearance of leadership

In short, these are the following tactics for carrying out the trick of the mysterious disappearance of leadership:

- pointing at the crucial issue, but then moving in all directions and being vague and contradictory concerning how to tackle it;

- stating the obvious as a uniting vision and then living the vision through improving social relations;
- limiting one's role to presenting ideas and then letting the others decide, a kind of minimalistic influencing;
- stating one leadership principle as crucial and then contradicting it in practice;
- doing primarily other things than the leadership argued to be very important; and
- providing space for others and largely abdicating the influence process.

These are not what the majority of authors on leadership lead us to expect. For these authors, an active subject trying ambitiously to exercise a coherent and systematic influence within an asymmetrical relation is viewed as typical in leadership.

What does all this tell us about leadership? Of course, one may assume that leadership always exists and use a very generous category in which almost everything can be included. We may then say that we have discovered cases of democratic, postheroic, participatory, and/or empowerment-facilitating leadership or that laissez-faire or fragmentary leadership is exercised in this company. Leadership can, perhaps, be everything and nothing. A review of the literature sometimes gives this impression (see [Palmer & Hardy, 2000](#)). Also, with sufficiently broad categorization of leadership, accounts or behaviors of managers going well beyond providing direction could be seen as examples of such categorization.

Alternatively, and perhaps preferably, the term leadership could be used to make sense of situations, relations, or people only under certain preconditions. More is needed than an organization and somebody labeled “manager” asked to put X's in a questionnaire or respond to interview questions about leadership. Let us for a moment return to the influential definition of leadership cited earlier. Here, [Yukl \(1989\)](#) defines leadership broadly: “to include influencing task objectives and strategies, influencing commitment and compliance in task behavior to achieve these objectives, influencing group maintenance and identification, and influencing the culture of an organization” (p. 253).

The problem is that this is not very helpful. Influencing all this in an important way is very rare—influencing culture, for example, is not easy and many, if not, most managers or supervisors do not influence strategies. With stringent criteria, one could say that very little leadership is exercised—a rare phenomenon indeed. With less stringent criteria, for example, moderate influencing, perhaps not only every supervisor but also virtually any employee exhibits leadership. An obnoxious individual providing a bad example or being used as a scapegoat may exert influence.

It makes more sense to talk about leadership if the influence process is significant and intended. (A lazy and incompetent manager may mean that subordinates take more initiative and responsibility and possibly develop in positive ways. The effects of negative, unintended influence can be illustrated by the case of a commander of a regiment who, according to our informant, had a very bad temper, and therefore his subordinates avoided communicating problems to him and were inclined to deal with these themselves.) It also makes more sense to see leadership as a matter of coherence than contradiction in terms of behavior, opposition between ideal and practice, and so forth. Needless to say, coherence needs to be comple-

mented by flexibility and adaptation to contingencies; whether a distinct style is called for or a wide spectrum of different behaviors is an option for managers is an issue for debate (e.g., Denison, Hooijberg, & Quinn, 1995; Palmer & Hardy, 2000).

The significance of the leader's influence appears as doubtful in the six cases previously presented, at least in terms of leadership. The persons focused may well be influential through working with budgets, participating in meetings where important decisions are made, or making administrative routines work effectively. However, these activities are not necessarily best labeled as leadership, and these activities are not what the interviewees refer to. We have not tried to assess the effects of the kind of leadership produced by our six managers. It would be meaningless, as there are hardly any simple mechanic cause–effect patterns that can be isolated, particularly not for this kind of leadership and in this organization. We may assume that the fairly passive, vague, and fragmented kinds of leadership—or the absence of it—do not indicate any important influence. Almost by definition, a vision that only repeats what one is supposed to do, listening to others, encouraging others to think, and then telling them which solution one prefers, allocating one minute to ask people very complex questions, and so forth does not provide much of a platform for important influence.

If we use even moderate criteria for coherence, clarity, link between idea and practice, and a certain level of ambition and systematicness for something to be labeled leadership there are reasons to doubt its “existence” in the present case. Of course, a discourse approach could say that there is language use around the signifier leadership and people may attribute leadership to what they do. Given these perspectives, the question of existence/nonexistence of leadership becomes less relevant and meaningful. As previously indicated, we link up with the broader discussions of leadership and take relations, actions, and meanings seriously. Given this reference point, we suggest that mainstream ideas about leadership—as expressed in the leadership literature and among practitioners—may assume too much. At least, in our study it seems very difficult to identify any specific relationships, behavioral styles, a coherent view or set of values, or an integrated, coherent set of actions that correspond to or meaningfully can be construed as leadership as important and intended. Thus, we arrive at the conclusion that there is not much leadership produced in the six cases.

8. Results and discussions

The empirical material of this study is, of course, limited to a particular organizational context. We must always consider context in studying social phenomena and in particular when addressing leadership (Bryman, Stephens & Campo, 1996). R&D work, particularly in the field in which the case company operates, is characterized by long-term processes, and much complexity and ambiguity and a high level of education make the relative autonomy of personnel and team organization important ingredients in the control situation (Alvesson and Sveningsson, *in press*). All this can limit the need and space for leadership, as well as the confidence of the managers to adapt a superior relationship to scientist subordinates. One

senior manager at the company studied emphasized that one of the most important tasks of senior management is to “strengthen the managerial identities of people.” Our empirical material indicates rather fluid orientations on leadership. Such orientations are not necessarily a problem; it cannot necessarily be taken for granted that a highly coherent sense of self is a positive thing (Deetz, 1992; Weedon, 1987).

It is thus tempting to say that leadership may be less salient or strong in this kind of context, it is, after all, a special case; in the great majority of organizational cases the situation is otherwise—that is, managers live up to standards and expectations. The case company is, however, a large, leading, international one and the managers are highly educated, typically with a PhD in the natural sciences. One should neither overgeneralize nor view the case as indicating something exceptional and marginal. To the extent that leadership is about influence processes it makes sense to allow space for considerable variation among different types of tasks, organizations, kinds of people, and societal and organizational cultures in terms of how these influencing processes may be shaped.

Sometimes it may be easier to find candidates—behaviors, relations, talk, values, cognitions—for leadership; sometimes the situation may be more similar to the one presented here. It cannot be taken for granted that the normal or typical situation is that leadership is something that is exercised in organizations.

There is certainly no shortage of other candidates for exercising influencing processes in organizations: organizational, industrial, professional and societal cultures, ideologies and discourses that often work mainly above or behind the seemingly influential actors, design arrangements and rules, peer groups and committees, management control systems, authorities and other institutions as well as customers exercising control, and so forth. That there is a strong discourse emphasizing leadership and that this is repeated by mass media, the public, people in organizations, and leadership researchers is no proof of anything—except, perhaps, about the popularity of this discourse. That there is considerable leadership research studying and claiming the existence of leadership does not prove anything either. Much of this research takes for granted leadership and is stuck in this assumption. The research assumes what it perhaps should study in a much more open and questioning way.

We do not doubt that it *sometimes* may be productive to understand subjects, relations, situations, and acts as leadership. Thus, we resist a poststructuralist impulse of a *strong* version of “everything is constituted within discourse” or a want to give an a priori privilege of “indeterminacy” and “fragmentation.” We see such a postmodernist perspective as *one* important rather than *the* point of view (Alvesson & Sköldberg, 2000). There are probably industrial and political key figures and also less grandiose individuals who pass the conception of leadership suggested earlier by Yukl. Our general impression is that it is difficult to say anything of the possible existence of leadership in the great majority of organizations and management situations.

We think that leadership agnosticism is called for—with much more caution on behalf of leadership researchers and others emphasizing and often celebrating “leadership.” The current interest in postheroic leadership (Huey, 1994), for example, leadership as care (Mintzberg, 1996) or as community development (Barker, 1997), may be a step forward.

However, why necessarily use the leadership label? There may be cases where leadership's implicit assumptions about rigid asymmetrical relationships and a core actor from which leadership flows are misleading. Our cases may be seen as a postleadership kind of organizational influencing process, that is, people in managerial positions being in mainly egalitarian positions and working with suggestions and encouragement more than anything else.

A productive *counterassumption* or idea would then be that leadership in any straightforward and clear sense perhaps is a very rare bird indeed. Leadership is routinely and with little hesitation “constructed” by managers, subordinates, journalists, leadership researchers, and others. It frequently is a highly shaky construction. A close and careful inspection may mean that leadership actually breaks down in certain contexts. In our case we can identify two such breakdowns: One is how common definitions of leadership do not correspond to the accounts produced by our case managers. Another is when their initial claim for what they do is contradicted by the efforts to show what this means in their application.

As Yukl (1989) notes, the numerous definitions of leadership that have been proposed appear to have little else in common than involving an influence process. Of course, if leadership means influence process, it would be absurd to deny it a formidable significance in organizations—and social and natural life in general—and it would be stupid even to raise the question of its existence. That influence processes take place is not too controversial.

However, if we try to be more specific the situation immediately changes. If we take the numerous definitions of leadership with little in common, then almost any instance of acting can be seen as leadership as well as *not* leadership, depending on the definitions. This is of course a basic dilemma; language use (discourse) matters as much as what actually goes on out there in terms of how we understand increasingly ambiguous phenomena. The numerous and great variety of definitions, however, undermines any pretense of leadership existing in any specific sense. Common sense and common-sense-based research—including structured approaches, where subjects are forced to produce indications of leadership for, say, questionnaire studies, make a loud and sometimes deafening case for leadership. More subtle interpretative work in which the nuances of language use are focused and accounts of leadership are open and opened up for alternative interpretations sometimes, at least, speak in a very different voice.

Of course, the previous argument has strong implications for the methodology of research on (what the researcher thinks is) leadership, what managers do and/or influence processes in organizations. It is not unlikely that a questionnaire or an interview study guided by an assumption that leadership exists would come up with a picture of the managers in the case company as strongly oriented to visions and value leadership as well as highly participative leadership. Of course, all research leads to results that reflect the methods—and, in the present case, we must be aware of the possibility that the responses indicate people's shortcomings in producing coherent interview responses about what they do as much as shortcomings in producing leadership in practice. We recommend an approach in which some exploration in depth of what people mean, combined with a considerable openness for—without a privileging of—incoherence, variation, and fragmentation is utilized. Here we recommend ethnographies. Otherwise, leadership research too easily encourages a recycling

of versions of the broadly shared discourses on leadership and takes the existence of this phenomenon as both for granted and very difficult to unpack.

9. Conclusions

Let us summarize the three conclusions of our study. First, managers in the studied organization—a very large and respected knowledge company—have rather vague and contradictory notions of leadership. They embrace notions of working with ideas and visions, but seem to manage to do so only in vague ways. It is difficult to see how the managers/leaders do something distinct or establish a clear asymmetrical relationship where the exercise of leadership makes managers more important than others. Perhaps we can talk of “minimalistic leadership,” but the study raises the question of the value of the leadership construct in the company and field being studied, that is, knowledge-intensive R&D work, and possibly in organizations in general.

Second, the cases encourage the broader question of the importance—indeed existence—of leadership in (some) organizational contexts. It is clear that there are strong ideological overtones around the idea of leadership—in general as well as in the cases studied—and that much of the leadership industry may produce leadership as something distinct and robust without careful consideration of the reasons for doing so. We have argued that this phenomenon is more fragile than the literature typically assumes. Leadership may be seen as a discursive position that managers (and perhaps some others) sometimes take or aspire to take, but it seems to be a position that is difficult to stick with—despite strong normative encouragements from management educators, the business press, and frequently senior and subordinate people in organizations to carry out leadership. The empirical material points to the disappearance of leadership. A closer look sensitive to incoherencies and deviations from the claimed characteristics of leadership means that it dissolves; even as a discourse it is not carried through. Not even the massive presence of scripts for leadership articulation in contemporary organizations, provided by popular press and management educators, seems to be sufficient to produce coherent treatment of the subject matter.

Third, we also draw attention to methodological problems and underscore the need for a more open and questioning approach. It would be premature to kill off leadership as a concept and legitimate research field through a single case study. And many would claim personal experiences and research pointing at a different direction than the one we suggest. However, the very strong dissatisfaction with the results of an enormous amount of leadership research encourages thinking through issues in unprejudiced ways. For leadership/leadership research to be more convincing perhaps much more openness, suspicion, and reflexivity need to characterize researchers (Alvesson & Sköldbberg, 2000). In terms of research design, more precise, in-depth qualitative research open to other vocabularies and lines of interpretations than “leadership-centric” ones are called for. There are perhaps too many studies assuming and producing leadership through designs with inbuilt “proofs” of leadership, carried out by researchers ideologically and commonsensically committed to this idea. We suggest that the

possible existence of leadership—as behavior, meanings, identity, and discourse—should be critically studied, not be taken for granted.

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